

Choosing the opening bid

Five-card majors, four-card diamonds. Reference: FIGB Fiori 2022, pages 24–27.

With a balanced hand (4333, 4432, 5332), check the high-card point range first:

HCP	Opening
15–17	1NT
21–23	2NT
24 or more	2♣, then describe the balanced hand

With balanced 12–14 or 18–20 HCP, open a suit: a major requires five cards; otherwise 1♦ requires four diamonds, or open 1♣ even with only two clubs.

With an unbalanced 12–20 HCP: open the only long suit, or, with two suits both at least five cards long, the higher-ranking suit as specified in Fiori 2022.

Strong suit openings: 21+ HCP or about 8½–9 winners. The suit must be six cards long, or five with another suit of at least four cards. Counting winners is different from counting HCP.

2♣ is ambiguous: a balanced 24+ HCP or a strong club-based hand. Strong suit openings are forcing for one round: responder must not pass.

Example: ♠J ♥KQJ74 ♦AK4 ♣AQ63 = 20 HCP. It is not balanced: the ordinary opening is 1♥, not 1♣ and not automatically 2♥.